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Project Deliverable 1 – Project Proposal

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1.1 Introduction

South Africa's e-commerce sector is expanding rapidly. According to World Wide Worx and Mastercard (2025), the country's online retail turnover could exceed R130 billion in 2025, with digital platforms now making up almost 10% of all retail spend. What is notable about this growth is that a large portion of it isn't occurring in the formal retail. More and more people are venturing into the consumer to consumer platforms to make money, and many of them are doing so without any kind of business registration or dedicated digital infrastructure (Standard Bank, 2025). The opportunity created by this is significant, but so are the gaps it reveals.

Those gaps are most evident at the level of everyday informal work. In most South African suburbs and townships, community WhatsApp groups are filled with the same types of requests every week: someone wants a gardener, a painter for the outside walls, a cleaner for a once off job or a pair of hands for a move. These requests are filled by word of mouth and the entire arrangement is played out on the trust, cash in hand, and hope that things will go well on the day. There is no means to check a worker's track record before employing them, no payment protection if the job is not done right, and no means for the worker to build a reputation that follows from client to client.

The scale of the problem is obvious if you look at the employment figures. As of the first quarter of 2025 South Africa's official unemployment rate stands at 32.9% and the expanded rate, which includes the number of people who have given up looking for work, at 43.1% (Statistics South Africa, 2025). Among young people between the ages of 15 and 24, that number rose to 62.4%. The Brookings Institution highlights that South Africa is located in the context of one of the highest youth unemployment contexts on the African continent - and digital platforms are one of the only realistic pathways to income inclusion on this scale (Nguimkeu, 2025). The informal economy, which takes in a large proportion of these workers, currently lacks the infrastructure to make that pathway work fairly or reliably.

SweepSouth, which was launched in 2014, is frequently cited as proof that a market for digitised domestic services exists in South Africa. With more than 1.2 million cleaners registered on it, the demand is clearly there (Rest of World, 2024). But SweepSouth has been widely criticised for the way it treats the workers on which it depends. According to an investigation by Rest of World (2024), workers can be blocked from the app permanently after a single complaint from a client, with no possibility of responding or defending themselves. Clients occasionally require extra work, which is not paid, and workers agree because of fear of being flagged. There is no neutral mechanism for resolving disputes and payment is not held in such a way as to protect workers from clients who refuse to confirm that a job has been completed.

HustleHub is a C2C service marketplace that is designed to solve these specific failures. Workers list their services at a fixed price and clients book directly as is done in the case of Fiverr. The defining feature is an escrow payment system: the client makes a payment when he or she books, the money is held until the job has been confirmed as completed by the client, and then it is released to the worker. If there is a disagreement, an admin is able to take over and see both sides of the argument and determine how the funds should be handled. The platform is focused on physical household activities: cleaning, gardening, painting, furniture moving and minor repairs. Keeping the scope of this narrow allows the platform to be simple to use and realistic to build within the project time frame using the stack of required technologies in this example (html, css, JavaScript, PHP, and MySQL).

Sources for Section 1.1: World Wide Worx and Mastercard 2025 Standard Bank 2025 Statistics South Africa 2025 Nguimkeu 2025 Rest of World 2024

1.2 Needs / Problems

1.2.1 Who This Platform Is For

The main users of HustleHub are informal physical service workers who are based in townships and peri-urban communities. These are people who provide cleaning, gardening, painting, moving, and general repair services but currently have no structured way of advertising and accepting bookings. According to the SweepSouth's annual report for 2024, there are more than 1.2 million domestic workers in South Africa and 92% of them are women (SweepSouth, 2024). Statistics South Africa revealed that 843 000 domestic workers were formally employed for Q2 2024 - which translates to a large number working in a position that still does not have a contract, is not registered with the UIF, or does not have any sort of protection (BusinessTech, 2024).

The secondary users are clients, which is the homeowners, tenants, and small property managers who already look for these services through Facebook groups and community chats but have no quality assurance, verified profiles, or payment protection available to them. Both groups are at actual danger in all informal transactions that they enter.

1.2.2) How Long This Problem Has Been in Existence

Informal domestic and physical service work in South Africa is a pre-internet phenomenon. It has always been arranged through personal referrals and face-to-face trust. The one significant attempt to digitise it at scale has been SweepSouth, which has been operating since 2014. Over ten years later, the fundamental problems of worker vulnerability and lack of payment protection are still not resolved, and there has been no alternative local platform that has challenged the status quo.

SweepSouth's own 2024 report documents that in just a year of time the cost of living for workers rose by 15% while their earnings only rose by 5% (SweepSouth, 2024). The minimum wage for domestic workers was fixed at R28.79 per hour in 2025, however, the average worker on SweepSouth is paid about R3 349 per month, which is less than what a full-time worker on the above hours should be earning at that rate (BusinessTech, 2025). Seventy-seven percent of domestic workers surveyed were not registered with UIF by their employer (BusinessTech, 2024). These figures attest that the existing digital infrastructure has not improved material conditions, nor has anything replaced it with something fairer.

1.2.3) Platforms that Exist and Are Lacking

SweepSouth Launched 2014. More than 1.2 million cleaners registered. Workers can be permanently blocked after one complaint from the client without any process for self-defence (Rest of World, 2024).

Workers are routinely asked to do unpaid additional duty. No escrow or payment protection. There is no neutral mechanism for resolving a dispute.

SweepSouth has recognised these concerns but has not acted on them at a structural level (Rest of World, 2024).

Facebook Marketplace Free and widely used but does not provide a booking system, no payment protection, no rating or verification system.

Commonly used for informal service advertising in townships but entirely exposes both parties.

WhatsApp Community Groups- The most common way that township residents find local service workers. Completely informal, no verification, no receipts, no recourse.

Workers have no opportunity to bring a verifiable reputation from one client to the next.

The pattern is the same with all three: current choices either open workers to exploitation or provide no protection for anyone. HustleHub is designed to fill the gap that none of them currently occupy: a local, mobile-friendly platform where both sides of a service transaction are treated fairly.

1.2.4) The Five Core Problems

No payment protection to workers. Informal workers are paid in cash after the job, if at all. On SweepSouth, payment flows through the platform, however, there is no mechanism to prevent a client from refusing to mark a job as complete. Workers doing unpaid over hours is a documented pattern in the Rest of World 2024 investigation.

HustleHub solves this with a holding of client payment in escrow from the time of booking, and the worker receives it once the job is confirmed done.

No quality assurance to clients. Clients that get workers via WhatsApp or Facebook, for instance, have no way to vet ratings, prior work or verify identity before committing. Makhitha and Ngoben (2023) found that two factors stand out as most important in determining whether township consumers adopt online platforms at all; perceived ease of use and trust. Without a transparent profile and rating system, the risk is all put on the client every time.

No neutral system of dispute resolution. When something goes wrong on SweepSouth, the outcome is left to its discretion. Workers report that the default platform is the client's account, because clients are the fee paying customers of the platform itself (Rest of World, 2024). On HustleHub, disputes are handled by an admin with access to both sides of the booking record who can release or refund the escrow funds based on what the evidence actually shows.

Workers lack opportunity to generate a digital reputation. A cleaner who has done excellent work in thirty households has little to offer a new client except his word. Nguimkeu (2025) has identified the creation of digital identities for informal workers as one of the most valuable contributions that a gig platform can make in a developing-economy context. HustleHub's profile and review system does just that: every completed booking contributes a verifiable piece of data for a worker's public profile.

Most platforms are not designed for township users. Existing platforms are targeted for users with reliable data connections and mid-range devices. Township communities also still bare the greater cost of data, and often make use of entry level Android handsets. A slow-to-load or confusingly navigable platform on a small screen will simply not be used no matter how good the underlying idea is. HustleHub is mobile-first from the beginning, and the feature set is kept intentionally minimal so that the user can navigate through it with any basic smartphone.

1.2.5) Effect on Target and Surrounding Populations

The combined result of these five issues is that township service workers are locked out of consistent, protected income. They have no means of proving their quality to strangers, of having recourse when clients exploit them, or of having the digital record of the work they have already done well. The surrounding economic impact is equally real: Money spent through informal, untracked transactions does not support the sort of commercial activity that creates jobs and puts money back into communities. Standard Bank (2025) puts the economy of the township at almost R900 billion a year and much of that involves service transactions taking place without any digital record or protection. One verified booking at a time, HustleHub's aim is to change that.

Sources: Statistics South Africa (2025), SweepSouth (2024), Rest of World (2024), BusinessTech (2024, 2025), Nguimkeu (2025), Makhitha and Ngobeneni (2023), Standard Bank (2025).

1.3 Goals / Objectives

Goal 1: Develop a C2C service booking platform with escrow payment that works

Build a web application (full stack) in the web (using your own web server) where workers can post the physical services they offer at a fixed price and clients can book and pay for it. The escrow model collects payment at the point of booking it and holds it in the transactions table with a status of 'held'. The status is only changed to 'released' when the client confirms that the job is done. This is a direct answer to the payment protection issue.

- Success measure: Each booking that is completed passes through the escrow model. There is no booking that can be marked complete unless there is some client confirmation or an administrative override. The transactions table reflects the correct status of the booking lifecycle at each stage of the booking lifecycle.
- Benefit: Workers are paid guaranteed money once they have a job confirmed to be completed. Clients may not receive a service and walk away without initiating a dispute process.

Goal 2: Develop a worker profile system and two-way star ratings

Workers will have to review their account before any listing goes live. After a booking is completed, both client and worker rate each other on a 1 to 5 star scale and have a written comment. Worker profiles show the average rating, number of jobs completed, and all individual reviews. This clears both the client quality issue and lack of digital reputation for workers.

- Success measure: No listing is visible in the list until worker's account is verified. Every completed booking results in a rating prompt for both parties. Worker profiles display correct aggregate ratings based on actual entries in the reviews table.
- Benefit: Clients have the ability to make informed decisions before booking. Workers build up a track record that can be verifiable and increases with each job performed and decreases the cold start problem with each new client.

Goal 3: Develop an admin dispute module with manual escrow control

The admin portal should have a provision for either party to raise a dispute of any active or completed booking. When a dispute is raised, the admin will be notified and will be able to view the statements of both parties and the full booking history and choose to release the funds to the worker, issue full or partial refund to the client, or ask for more

information before making a decision. Every action of an admin is recorded with the timestamp and the ID of the admin's account.

- Success measure: The complete workflow of the dispute is tested end to end: dispute raised, admin notified, admin reviews and acts, transaction status updated, resolution note saved. At least two admin roles are implemented: Super Admin and Moderator which have defined permissions.
- Benefit: Neither party has unilateral power of the outcome of a dispute. The admin acts as a neutral middleman with a full audit trail for reference, which is precisely what is lacking from all existing platforms in this space.

Goal 4: Design and create a mobile first design that works on a 3G connection

All the pages are created mobile first using Bootstrap 5's grid system, with the media queries for breakpoints at 320px, 768px and 1024px. Images use lazy loading. All main pages should load and work correctly on a simulated 3G connection using the Chrome DevTools and the platform should be tested physically on at least one Android device before being submitted.

- Success measure: All of the core pages load in 4 seconds using a simulated 3G connection. The platform works perfectly on screens that are 320px wide and above. Physical testing of an Android device is covered in project documentation.
- Benefit: The platform is truly available to the township users for whom it is designed, not just the fast connected and newer handsets.

Goal 5: Successfully go through end-to-end booking cycles in user acceptance testing

Before submitting, the platform must prove at least three full cycles of bookings in user acceptance testing. Every cycle must span the entire workflow from a worker listing a service, to a client booking and simulating payment, to the booking moving to completion, to the client confirming the job completed so that the escrow funds are released. At least one of these cycles needs to include a dispute being brought up and resolved by an admin. This validates the core logic of the platform to function as a connected system, and not as individual features disconnected from one another.

- Success measure: Three complete cycles of bookings are recorded with screenshots at each phase. One cycle of dispute is completed with an admin resolution added to the disputes table. All the transitions of the escrow status are validated as correct in the transactions table at all the test cycles.
- Benefit: This confirms that the platform works as a real system and not a series of separate pages. It also gives concrete evidence to the Deliverable 3 presentation and a User Manual has real data to document.

Sources for Section 1.3: Rest of World (2024); Statistics South Africa (2025); Nguimkeu (2025); Makhitha and Ngobeni (2023).

1.4) Procedures / Scope of Work

1.4.1) What Is Being Built

HustleHub is a collection of two web applications, which are using one MySQL database. The first is the main marketplace, which is used by workers and clients. The second is an admin portal that is only viewable by people with an admin or moderator role, this is secured using PHP session checks on every page. Both applications are designed using the module's required stack, which is the following: HTML5, CSS3 with Bootstrap 5, JavaScript with jQuery for the development of the AWS (Ajax Web Services), PHP 8.x for the implementation of all the logic that the server performs or PHP 8.x to the data storage, which is MySQL 8.x. There are no CMS tools like WordPress or Wix used. Development is done locally using Vscode, Version control is done using GitHub, and the platform is hosted on InfinityFree for the final presentation.

The system is deliberately kept simple. The entire platform is based on six tables in a database and the trickiest logic is a booking status field which goes through a defined process of states. This is a normal CRUD application with booking and escrow flow. It is buildable within the timeframe by one developer.

Table	What It stores
Users	All users: workers, clients, and admins. A role column controls access. OTP verification status is tracked here.
Services	Service listings created by workers: title, description, category, fixed price, estimated duration, and admin approval status.
Bookings	Each booking a client makes. Status progresses through: pending, confirmed, in_progress, completed, disputed, or cancelled.
Transactions	One financial record per booking: the amount, and escrow status (held, released, or refunded). Admin can update this during a dispute.
Reviews	Post-completion ratings from both parties: star score (1 to 5), written comment, linked to the booking to prevent duplicates.
Disputes	Dispute records: which booking is disputed, who raised it, the reason, current status (open or resolved), admin resolution note, and timestamps.

The basic flow of the booking process is as follows: the worker lists a service, the client books and pays, the worker does the job, the client verifies it's done and the escrow funds are released. If the client is unsatisfied, they initiate a dispute and the admin intervenes. That is the whole core logic of the platform.

1.4.2) Phase 1 Research and Requirements (Weeks 1 to 3)

This phase includes the literature and background research that is used to inform the proposal. It also generates the system design documents needed in Deliverable 2: CRC cards for each entity, an EERD mapping the six tables and their relationships, a Context Diagram to define the system boundary and a Level 1 DFD to trace the booking, payment and dispute processes. Use case scenarios are written for three types of actors - Worker, Client and Administrator.

1.4.3) Phase 2: Prototyping (Weeks 3 to 4)

Responsive wireframes for all the main pages are made on Figma before the code is ever written. The pages that were required to have wireframes are: Landing and Browse, Worker Profile, Service Detail and Booking, Client Dashboard, Worker Dashboard, Admin Dashboard, Dispute Panel, and Login and Registration. Each of the wireframes shows three breakpoints for mobile (320px to 767px), tablet (768px to 1024px), and desktop (1025px). The HustleHub colour scheme incorporates navy, orange and white across the board.

1.4.4) Phase 3: Database and Backend (Weeks 4 until 6)

Database setup comes first: all of the six tables are created in phpMyAdmin with the correct column type, foreign key constraints, and test seed data. PHP development is based on a simple folder structure, where the files of the database connection are placed in the folder config/, the files of pages that can be used in other pages are placed in the folder includes/, the files of pages go to the folder pages/, and finally, the files of the admin portal go to the folder admin/. The core PHP modules are five and are as follows:

- User Authentication: Registration (with email based (OTP) verification), login (using PHP Sessions), Password hashing using (BCRYPT) and role based redirects (to ensure that workers, clients and admins land on the right dash board after login).
- Service Listings: Workers have the ability to create, edit and delete their own listings. Admins can approve or reject listings from the admin panel before the listings go public. Clients have the ability to browse by category and keyword search.
- Booking and Escrow: The client chooses a service, selects a date for the service, and confirms the booking. A simulated payment logs a row of transactions with status 'held'. The booking status is changed as the job progresses. When the client clicks to confirm the completion status, the PHP logic is changed to 'released' for the transaction status.
- Disputes: Either party may initiate a dispute on an active / completed booking. The admin views all the open disputes in the portal and can view the booking

history and statements of both the parties and update the transaction to 'released' or 'refunded' with a written resolution note.

- **Reviews:** Once a booking is set as complete, each party would be asked to rate the other. The star rating and comment are written to the reviews table and the average rating for the worker is recalculated and displayed on their profile.

Note on payments: payment is simulated in this project, instead of integrated with a live gateway. The reason for this is to illustrate the logic of escrow, not to process real transactions. A "Pay Now" button logs the payment as "held" in the database. This is an orthodox method for academic web development projects at this level.

1.4.5) Phase 4: Frontend (Weeks 5 to 7)

The addition of all the functionality is done in a mobile-first way with the help of Bootstrap 5's grid system that is written in all the different types of CSS and HTML. JavaScript is used in the site for jQuery, Ajax based booking status updates, dynamic filtering of listings based on category and price, character counter on review input fields, and for image upload previews on the service listing form. No frontend framework apart from Bootstrap and jQuery is used. This keeps the codebase within the requirements of the module and manageable by a single developer.

1.4.6) Phase 5: Testing (Week 7)

Testing is conducted in three fields. Functional testing is executed in each booking flow, escrow transition, dispute path, and admin action against a written list of test cases. Responsive testing uses Chrome Devtools to use device emulation to test layouts in Chrome on a Galaxy A-series phone, an iPad mini, and a 1920px desktop with a physical Android device used to test for real world confirmation. Security testing checks that user inputs to the site are processed using PDO prepared statements, that the output of any web page has properly escaped, that all web forms have CSRF tokens, and that the session IDs are regenerated when a user logs in.

1.4.7) Phase 6 User Onboarding and Training (Weeks 7 to 8)

Since HustleHub is aimed at users that may not have experience with structured digital booking platforms, the onboarding experience is part of the build rather than an afterthought. Workers and clients will find their way through a brief walkthrough given on their first login, with a step-by-step welcome flow that's built in and written in JavaScript and points out some of the key actions: creating a listing for workers, and searching and booking a service for clients. This walkthrough can be dismissed and accessed again at anytime from the user dashboard.

In addition, there will be a dedicated Help page within the platform, with the most common questions to every type of user in simple terms. These include how the escrow

system works, what happens in the event of a dispute being raised, and how to update or remove a listing. The User Manual produced as a part of Deliverable 3 will be used as the extended version of this guidance, with annotated screenshots providing step-by-step walk-through of every main feature. Together, the in-platform walkthrough, the Help page, and the User Manual make up the bulk of the training and support plan for HustleHub.

1.4.8) Phase 7: Implementation: And Writing It Up (Weeks 7 to 8)

The platform is deployed to InfinityFree at least a week before the presentation of the Deliverable 3, as it is required by the project specification. The GitHub repository is made accessible for submitting code. The User Manual is created using minimum 15 annotated screenshots. All of the Deliverable 2 documentation is finished and posted by Block 2 Week 5.

Development Tools: VS Code, XAMPP, Figma, GitHub, InfinityFree, Chrome DevTools.
Stack: HTML5, CSS3, Bootstrap 5, JavaScript ES6, jQuery 3.x, PHP 8.x, MySQL 8.x.

1.5) Timetable

Deliverable	Key Activities	Start to End
Deliverable 1	Literature research, problem analysis, comparator review (SweepSouth, Facebook, WhatsApp), goal formulation, scope of work, Gantt chart, proposal writing.	Block 1, Week 1 to Block 1, Week 4
Deliverable 2	Figma wireframes for all pages across three breakpoints, system diagrams (EERD, DFD, Context Diagram, Use Case Diagram, CRC cards), MySQL schema, PHP backend, HTML/CSS/JS frontend, escrow and booking logic, testing, documentation.	Block 1, Week 3 to Block 2, Week 5
Deliverable 3	Live deployment to public hosting, user acceptance testing (three complete booking cycles including one dispute), User Manual production with 15 or more annotated screenshots, presentation preparation.	Block 2, Week 6 to Summative Schedule

1.5.1) Gantt Chart

Activity	Wk 1	Wk 2	Wk 3	Wk 4	Wk 5	Wk 6	Wk 7	Wk 8
D1: Background Research	•	•						
D1: Problem Analysis	•	•	•					
D1: Proposal Writing		•	•	•				
D2: Wireframes (Figma)			•	•				
D2: System Diagrams			•	•	•			
D2: MySQL Database Schema				•	•			
D2: PHP Backend				•	•	•		
D2: HTML / CSS / JS Frontend					•	•	•	
D2: Testing						•	•	
D2: Documentation							•	
D3: Hosting and Deployment							•	•
D3: User Manual							•	•
D3: Presentation								•

1.6 Conclusion

South Africa's overall digital economy is growing at a rate. The country's online retail sector is predicted to surpass R130 billion in 2025, accounting for almost 10% of the retail spending (World Wide Worx and Mastercard, 2025). But the informal sector that employs almost 20% of the working population and accounts for a township economy that is estimated to value R900 billion a year (Standard Bank, 2025) has been not been a meaningful part of that growth. The tools that do exist exploit the workers that use them, or provide no protection whatsoever. The disconnect between informal, untracked work

available in service and a fair and safe digital marketplace has been documented well and has not been bridged.

HustleHub is a direct and practical solution to that gap. By narrowing down this to getting physical household services, and having a fixed-price listing model, the platform remains simple enough to use and simple enough to build. The escrow system is not a complex financial instrument: It is a status field in a transactions table that is part of a PHP logic system. The rating system is conventional CRUD. The dispute module is a notification, a review page and a fund control action for the admin. None of this requires technology outside of what is specified in the module and none of it requires more than one developer to finish within the project timeframe.

The potential impact of a platform like this extends beyond the individual user. If HustleHub provides even a number of township service workers with a profile, a growing rating and a guaranteed payment on each confirmed job, it helps to move informal work from something invisible and unprotected into something documented and reliable. Nguimkeu (2025) describes this as the most important contribution digital platforms can make to labour markets in developing economies: turning work that is survivalist and invisible, into work that is formal, verifiable, and capable of growing. At a national level platform that ensure transaction revenue remains in South Africa, financial inclusion for workers who do not have access to a bank account, and bringing informal trade into the formal system is consistent with the economic development objectives outlined by Standard Bank (2025). HustleHub is one step in that direction, and a step that is achievable within this project.

The proposal has outlined the problem, the evidence to support it, five measurable goals, a realistic scope, and a workable timetable. Deliverable 2 will transform this to prototypes, diagrams and working code. Deliverable 3 will deliver a fully hosted platform with a documented user journey. This document is the basis of both.

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